

Stylistic Variation

Choosing the right language for the context (Section C)

Study guide for the University of Ibadan Postgraduate Test of English (EPT)

Stylistic variation is about using language that suits its context. The same message can be written formally to a head of department or informally to a parent, and the EPT checks that you can tell which form belongs where. It also tests **Standard British English (SBE)** against local usage, and sentence transformations such as **active to passive**.

Step 1: Identify the context

Every stylistic-variation section begins with an instruction that sets the scene, for example a letter to the Vice-Chancellor, a letter to your father, or a report to your employer. Read it first, then judge each option against it.

	Formal (e.g. letter to a head of institution)	Informal (e.g. letter to a parent or friend)
Contractions	Avoid them: <i>is not, cannot, I am</i>	Acceptable: <i>isn't, can't, I'm</i>
Vocabulary	Standard, precise: <i>informed, approval, available</i>	Everyday words are fine
Slang and local expressions	Never	Still avoid in an exam; use standard English
Abbreviations	Write in full, or use the recognised form: <i>Vice-Chancellor</i>	Common abbreviations acceptable
Tone	Respectful and impersonal	Warm and personal (<i>Dad, ...</i>)

EXAM TIP

Save time: once you know the context, cross out options that break its rules (a contraction in a formal letter, a slang word), then compare what is left for grammar.

Step 2: Check grammar and word choice

Stylistic options often differ in concord, tense, prepositions or spelling as well as style. The right answer must be **appropriate and correct**.

- **Tense with time expressions.** *Two days ago* needs the past tense; *at the moment* needs the present.

- **Confusable pairs.** *advise* (verb) and *advice* (noun); *lend* (give temporarily) and *borrow* (take temporarily); *hanged* (people) and *hung* (objects); *childish* (negative) and *childlike* (positive); *fond of*, not *found of*.
- **Fixed prepositions.** *charged with an offence, in the long run, advise on, rise to one's feet.*
- **Uncountable nouns.** *information, equipment, advice* never take *-s*.
- **British spelling and style.** *storey* (floor of a building), *programme, centre, colour*. British style writes *Mr, Mrs, Dr* without a full stop.

Step 3: Standard British English, not local usage

Some expressions common in Nigerian English are not Standard British English. In the exam, choose the standard form.

Avoid (local usage)	Use (Standard British English)
on the light / off the light	switch on / switch off the light
I am coming (meaning "wait, I'll be back")	I'll be right back
flash me	give me a missed call
go-slow	traffic jam / traffic congestion
my senior brother	my elder (or older) brother
borrow me your pen	lend me your pen
severally	several times / repeatedly
extra lesson	private tutoring / extra classes
declare a party / throw a bash	host a party
well done (as a greeting to someone working)	good afternoon / hello
he is stranded (for having no money)	he is short of money
tight friend	close friend

NOTE

Many of these are understood across Nigeria. The point is not that they are "wrong" in daily life, but that the EPT measures Standard British English.

Step 4: Active and passive structures

Some items ask you to change a sentence from the **active** (the doer comes first) to the **passive** (the thing acted on comes first). The rules:

1. The object of the active sentence becomes the subject of the passive.
2. Use a form of **be** in the **same tense** as the active verb, followed by the **past participle**.

3. The doer moves after *by*, in the **object** form: *I* → *me*, *we* → *us*, *he* → *him*, *she* → *her*, *they* → *them*.

Tense	Active	Passive
Present simple	I see a bird.	A bird <u>is seen</u> by me.
Present continuous	I am feeding the bird.	The bird <u>is being fed</u> by me.
Present perfect	I have fed the bird.	The bird <u>has been fed</u> by me.
Past simple	I fed the bird.	The bird <u>was fed</u> by me.
Past continuous	I was feeding the bird.	The bird <u>was being fed</u> by me.
Future	I will feed the bird.	The bird <u>will be fed</u> by me.

EXAM TIP

Check two things in every passive option: the tense of *be* must match the original verb, and the pronoun after *by* must be the object form (*by her*, never *by she*).

Registers of different fields

The EPT may use contexts from particular disciplines (construction, health, agriculture, law). Get familiar with the standard terms of at least a few fields. For example, in construction: *a two-storey building, the foundation was cast, the materials are of standard quality*.

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